

The Voice Of The Process

The control limits are the process itself, calculated from its own behavior, telling you the range it naturally lives in.

The Drift

A manufacturer filled bottles to five hundred milliliters, averaging right on target after an improvement. The control limits, calculated from the process, came out near four ninety four and five oh six. For weeks the points bounced happily inside, four ninety eight, five oh two, just noise, and the team correctly left it alone.

The Signal

One Tuesday a point landed at four ninety three, just below the lower limit. A customer would never notice seven missing milliliters, and watching only the target they would have shrugged. But the chart compared to the voice of the process, and that point was the process shouting that something had changed.

Caught Early

They investigated immediately and found a filling nozzle starting to clog. Caught that day it was a five minute cleaning. Left alone, fills would have drifted down until customers complained and a run was scrapped. The chart turned an expensive crisis into a trivial maintenance task by catching the drift early.

Remember this

You relax while points stay inside the limits and spring into action only when the process raises its hand.